Leave-Request Demo: Setup and Run Sheet

AI Administrator · Day 3 · Session 5 · Automation Basics with n8n

Instructor setup sheet · tested 11 October 2026

What you are running

The Session 4 first build as a real n8n workflow: **S5 Demo - Leave request** (`workflows/Day3_S5_Leave_Request_Demo.json`, 8 nodes and a sticky note). A leave form feeds a balance lookup in Google Sheets, a policy check (fictional policy HR-POL-02: 1 to 2 days need 2 working days' notice, 3 or more need 10; Friday and Saturday are the weekend; the last two weeks of a quarter also need the department head), and an IF. Requests that pass are logged as **Pending manager** and a decision card is e-mailed to the manager; requests that fail are logged as **Flagged for HR** with the reason, and HR is e-mailed. Nothing is approved or declined automatically.

No bot, no server and no API keys this session. Everything runs in your own n8n Cloud trial.

Once, a few days before Session 5

1. Open your n8n trial

Sign up at n8n.io/pricing, **Start free trial** (n8n Cloud, no credit card). Open it **no more than a few days before** the session: the trial lasts 14 days and must still be active on the last n8n day of the course. Note your workspace address (`yourname.app.n8n.cloud`).

2. Make the Google Sheet

1. Upload `Day3_S5_Leave_Demo_Sheet.xlsx` to Google Drive and open it in Google Sheets.
2. **File, Save as Google Sheets.** The uploaded copy has a green **XLSX** badge; n8n cannot read it (you get "403" or an empty list). Use the new native copy and note its link.
3. Do this in **the Google account you will connect in n8n**. In our test the sheet was first created in a different account and n8n returned *403 Forbidden, the caller does not have permission*.
4. Tab **Balances**: the four fictional employees (Lina Haddad has 2 days left, Omar Khalil 21, Sara Nasser 15). Tab **Requests**: headers only.

3. Import the workflow

In n8n: **Overview, Build a workflow**, then the three-dots menu next to the name, **Import, From file**, choose `Day3_S5_Leave_Request_Demo.json`. The workflow renames itself **S5 Demo - Leave request**. Red triangles on the Sheets and Gmail nodes are expected: no credentials yet.

4. Connect Google

1. Open **Look up balance**, Credential, **Sign in with Google**. On Google's consent screen choose the account that owns the sheet and **tick every box**. n8n names it "Google Sheets account".
2. Open **Flag to HR**, Credential, **Sign in with Google** again for Gmail ("Gmail account").
3. The other Sheets and Gmail nodes pick up the same credentials. If not, choose them from the Credential list.

5. Point the nodes at your sheet

1. In **Look up balance**: Document **By URL**, paste the sheet link; Sheet **From list**, choose **Balances** (if the list loads, access is right); Filters, **Add Filter**, Column **Email**, Value `{{ $json['Work email'] }}` in **Expression** mode (the toggle above the field; in Fixed mode it is matched as plain text).
2. In **Log request** and **Log flagged request**: the same link, Sheet **Requests**. The column mapping is already set.
3. In **Flag to HR**: change To from `hr@example.com` to your own address for the demo.

Changing the document resets the sheet and filter fields, so do it in this order: document, sheet, filter.

6. Test three times

Click **Execute workflow** (bottom centre), open the form's **Test URL** (in the form node, Form URLs) and submit:

Test	Full name	Work email	Manager email	Type	First day	Last day	Expected
1	Omar Khalil	omar.khalil@aicaravan.example	your address	Annual leave	15 Nov	17 Nov	Pending manager; decision card in your inbox
2	Sara Nasser	sara.nasser@aicaravan.example	your address	Annual leave	the day after tomorrow	same day	Flagged for HR: 1 working day notice, policy needs 2
3	Lina Haddad	lina.haddad@aicaravan.example	your address	Annual leave	15 Nov	17 Nov	Flagged for HR: asks for 3 days but only 2 remain

Click **Execute workflow** again before each submission: the test URL listens for one submission only. Check the **Requests** tab (Reason and Status columns) and the **Executions** tab (three green runs).

7. Reset

Delete the three test rows from **Requests** so the sheet is empty for the live demo. Keep the Executions; they are useful if the live run fails.

On the day

- Open the editor in its own browser window, zoomed to 125%, and the sheet in a second tab on **Requests**.
- Run test 1 live, then 2 and 3 if time allows (minute 35 to 55 in the deck).
- If Google fails live: show the **Executions** tab from your preparation runs and the screenshots in the deck. Keep the timing.

After the session

- Export the workflow (menu, **Export JSON**) and keep it with this package.
- Share `Day3_S5_Request_Intake_Solution.json` (the lab solution) in the chat or by e-mail. Participants import it with Import, From file and connect their own Google account.

What was verified on 11 October 2026

On n8n Cloud (trial, “Publish” editor): import from file, the form test URL, Google Sheets Get row(s) with a filter, the Code node, IF, Sheets Append row and Gmail Send on both branches; the three tests above produced the expected rows and e-mails. The lab solution produced *New*, *New* and *Incomplete* for amounts 200, 900 and blank, after one correction: **an empty number field arrives as 0**, so the guard must test *Amount is greater than 0*, not *is not empty*.